

Introduction

BEYOND INTERPRETATION

In approaching this introductory text, I am struck by the difficulty of a beginning. When painter Emilio Vedova was teaching at the Accademia di Belle Arti in Venice and one of his pupils would be paralysed in front of the empty canvas, he would dip a brush in the paint and lash it against the white surface. Was the pupil facing the void, and was Vedova's gesture interrupting such a void? Massimo Recalcati (2011) suggests the opposite. This gesture *looks for* a void, it tries to scar the overabundance of images that crowd the canvas, intimidating the pupil and preventing him or her from beginning. What the brushstroke breaks is not a void, but an array of prefigured knowledges, experiences, commonplaces, memories, modes of thinking, clichés, rules, and vetoes. "The cumbersome presence of dead signs is never a contingent experience. The white canvas is *always* full of dead knowledges, of inert elements, of monumental ideals" (ibid., translation and emphasis mine).

A creative act must always start *in medias res*, from the middle, as a break that looks for its void. The project that this book presents is in the field of artistic research, and thus includes a fundamental creative component. It takes as its field of creativity the performance of Western notated art music. What, then, is the empty, or rather the *overflowing*, "canvas" for a performer approaching a piece of written music? What is the middle that his or her creative act starts from?

For the moment, I would like to remain on the literal level of the phrase *the performance of written music*. "Written music" brings with itself the past, the already codified elements, the stratification of former practices; its "performance" is the reiteration of its life—its future and simultaneously its completion. Thus, the middle I want to and must start from is the—generally overlooked—preposition *of*. The performance *of* written music.

The canvas of the *of*, devoid of actual materiality and at the same time burdened with the virtual inertia of the past, is the place of a crucial transformation. Through it, the codified scores of the Western tradition are turned in a dimension that differs from them, both materially and operationally—that is to say, in the dimension of sound and gesture. Two different levels are put into correspondence; the performance of written music is thus a matter of semiotics, of *representation*. How does a system of signs allow a certain sonic and gestural materiality to take place? How is the correspondence between the notated sign and its material enactment constructed through performance? What dictates a *resemblance* between a score and its performance, given that their inscription occurs through materials and modalities that show no conformity with each

other (the first through immaterial symbols and on material visual media; the second in vibratory, haptic, and n-dimensional spatial materialities)?

As a team member of the research programme MusicExperiment21 (music-experiment21.eu), of which my own project is part, I have been engaged in the development of notions of “experimentation” with the aim of constituting and theorising new performance practices in the context of Western notated art music. One of the fundamental points of this programme was the move away from *musical interpretation*, regarded as the still dominant paradigm in the performative attitude towards past musical works. Whereas many performers in this musical context consider interpretation as the only possibility for describing their activity, MusicExperiment21 underlines the *epochal* nature of such a concept and term, and the partiality of the view it offers on musical works:

Rooted in positivist thinking . . . , “musical interpretation” has often been used to signify the way in which notation should be interpreted—pointing to a text-based understanding of the musical work. Predicated upon the existence of a fixed source text (the score), which preserves an idealised concept of the authorised “musical work,” and on a performer bringing the musical experience itself into renewed existence, the concept of “interpretation” implies a centripetal approach from the performer towards the supposed “essence” of the artwork itself and it is strongly related to other time-bound concepts, such as *Werktreue*, “authenticity,” “composer’s intention,” and, crucially, to certain editorial practices, particularly the *Urtext*. (Assis 2012)

The work done by MusicExperiment21 therefore has aimed at challenging traditional modes of thinking, both about the nature of musical works and about the practice of their performance. On the one hand, it has problematised the ontological character appointed to musical works by some musico-philosophical traditions (see Assis 2018, chapter 1). On the other hand, it has redefined the locus of performance as a place of experimentation, where instead of replicating the past through a set of inherited modalities and tools, “what we know” about a particular musical work is reshaped and constituted anew. Crucially departing from both applied musicology and performance studies, MusicExperiment21 situates itself within the field of artistic research, where knowledge production is inseparable from the constitution and reconfiguration of material practices and objects.

Throughout the project, a large part of MusicExperiment21’s activity has been directed towards reshaping the mode of thinking about “musical works” and “performance” that the notion of interpretation carries. Conversely, the specific aim of my project is to focus on the above mentioned “of.” Whereas the team’s research work has been mainly directed towards challenging the fixity of such categories, and instead moving towards the formulation of a dynamic theory for them, my choice was to observe musical works and their performance as relatively stable and unproblematised. The problematisation that I focus on in my research approach happens rather in the transferral from one form of inscription to the other, in the moment in which the symbolic dimension of the score shapes the incommensurably material one of the performance. At a later stage

of the research, from the circumscribed perspective of the “of,” partial redefinitions of what a musical work is and what performance is have also emerged.

TOWARD AN EXPERIMENTAL/DIVERGENT PERFORMANCE
PRACTICE

In an essay on the history of the terminology of music performance commissioned by MusicExperiment21, musicologist Hermann Danuser (2015, 187) remarks that “‘interpretation’ is based on texts and leads to texts: first, on the composer’s musical text and books on musical performance . . . and second, assuming that the work has been recorded, on the sonic text of a work.” I would take this remark even further, by adding that it is not only in cases in which a work has been recorded that interpretation leads to sonic texts. The materiality of the performative act in interpretation is shaped by a form of textuality that *makes a text* out of it. In other words, from the point of view of the transformation happening in the decisive “of,” it matters little whether the sonic inscription is recorded and fixed onto a phonographic medium or it takes place in the fleeting moment of the live performance. The textuality of the score is directly transferred into a sonic and gestural enactment that reflects—and *is* in turn—*text*. In his essay “Beyond the Interpretation of Music,” musicologist Laurence Dreyfus comments critically on interpretation. As he states, “Interpretation aspires to *reproduce* the composer’s spirit in a looking-glass, or . . . to be ‘a *mirror* which, held before an object, reflects it in its unclouded purity and truth’” (Dreyfus 2007, 263, emphasis mine). Before getting lost in suppositions about what a composer’s spirit might be and where it might be possible to locate it—if at all—a more basic question arises, How can a sound sequence *mirror* something that has nothing to do with sounds? Or, from the opposite end, What kind of reduction does a symbolic structure ask to be operated upon a material event in order for it to *resemble* itself, and according to which mediational apparatus?

In the text-based regime of interpretation, performance is therefore always vicarious. Critically, the overarching goal of my research project is to detach the performance of written music from its text, and to treat it as an independent kind of “writing”: one that does not try to reproduce, to represent, or to mirror anything, but that instead creates its own rules according to the materials and modalities in and through which it takes place, constructing its own world.

It is vital to pay attention to a small but decisive detail. What I want to detach from the textuality of written music is by no means “performance”—it is “performance *of*.” My creative activity therefore places a fundamental distance between itself and two pre-existing modalities. In the first place, it does not want to pose itself as a form of “performance” independent of a text. The practice in this direction already has a long history. It is far longer than that of musical textuality—if we remember that the fixation of sound sequences into a reproducible codification could become a habit and a mode of thinking only after the birth of the concept of composition due to the invention of music notation. Moreover, post-notational practice paths have already been abundantly traced by a multiplicity of experiences that have put the emphasis on

the “onstage” situation of music, diminishing the prominence of textual codification, as for example in experimental music.¹ In the second place, even if my artistic activity, as we shall see, entails elements of composition, it is fundamentally different from compositional processes. My musical activity rejects any form of symbolic codification of sounds. One of the claims of this research is that there is a form of sonic materiality that makes text of itself, which strongly implies its own notational codification and makes possible the production of a “resemblance” between text and sound. My aim is therefore also the production of a kind of materiality in performance that puts semiotic categories into crisis, jeopardising the very existence of a musical text. Moreover, my musical practice is not directed towards the constitution of new musical “repertoire.” In contrast, by referring to a pre-existing repertoire and by destabilising it, this practice aims at *taking away*, subtracting repertoire.

Again, we are back at the middle. My activity inhabits the space between the fleetingness of performance-as-event and the stratification into music-as-text. The “performance of” (written music) points to a referent (the notated musical work) and at the same time obliterates it, overwhelming it with the incommensurable materiality that is the fabric of performance. The new performances that I have been “writing” as artistic outputs of this project do not resemble the work that they depart from, as they question the whole apparatus that has made such a resemblance a possibility. If they resemble something of the work, they do so in a *divergent* way. They might not contain any single semiotic unit of the work’s score: any pitch, pattern, rhythm, colour, instrumental idiom, harmony, reference to tone system, or stylistic element. My task has been to depart from the original work as much as possible, but only to the point where “something” of it is retained. When I say “something,” I choose this word carefully. The indeterminacy that it entails is not an unpleasant drawback of the process; rather, it is the only condition for success when renouncing semiotic categories.

RESEARCH STRATEGIES, PERSPECTIVES, AND LIMITS

In the variety of examples, musical experiences, different disciplines, concepts, and references that are addressed in this book, it is important to keep in mind that the point of view is always very particular, and the focus extremely concentrated. Each musical activity (composition, improvisation, analysis, etc.) is always described not only as observed from the perspective of the performer, but also, even more specifically, by a performer who regards her activity through the infinitesimal locus of the “of.” I will proceed to introduce five main topics that have structured the research trajectory, and that emerge throughout the book. They are (1) the role of semiotics, (2) beyond authority and tradition, (3) the use of visual examples, (4) a “baroque regime” for the performance of written music, and (5) bodies and organisms.

1 In this sense it is interesting to note Morag J. Grant’s (2003) remark that experimental music operates a shift from a symbolic mode of signification to an indexical one, “presenting” itself instead of “representing.”